



THE DIGITAL MALAWI ACCELERATION PROJECT

GRANT NUMBER:
PROJECT NUMBER:

IDA-E338-MW
P505095

Provision of a turnkey solution for the rehabilitation, upgrading, and commissioning of the Central Printing Facility including design, supply, installation and handover for full operational readiness

We received request for clarifications regarding the above captioned procurement activity and in the spirit of fairness and transparency, the clarifications together with the questions are shared in the Table below.

Table 1: Responses to requests to Clarifications

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
Sections 3.4.2 and 3.4.3 on pages 169 and 170	Can we instead of “Photonic crystal patterns” propose DOVID element that also rest upon diffraction and refraction of light on tiny structures – creating movable images that changes the colour when tilted or rotated. Moreover, DOVID protects effectively both the cardholder image and other data underneath. Proposed DOVID would come from manufacturer that is ISO 14298	Bidders are advised that the minimum specifications detailed in the bidding document are non-negotiable at this stage unless amended through an Addendum issued or to be issued. Bidders must propose solutions that either meet or exceed the baseline requirements while delivering the specified benefits.

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	certified which additionally secure the process of ID document issuance	The photonic crystal serves as a security layer optimized for visual inspection via light manipulation and angle-dependent color shifts. Consequently, any alternative solution must be accompanied by a robust technical justification demonstrating equivalence in security performance and a clear competitive advantage.
	Having reviewed the requested specifications and the budget allocated by the World Bank, we believe that the overall project scope may exceed the current estimated budget. In particular, the deployment of two modular laser personalization systems and two automated mailing and dispatch systems, together with the production and supply of ID cards and the related installation, integration, testing, and commissioning activities, is expected to have a significant impact on the total project cost. In this regard, could you please confirm whether the estimated project budget has been revised or whether a budget adjustment is currently being considered?	Bidders are advised to submit their financial proposals based on the proposed solution and not the estimated budget.
	Considering the scope and complexity of the required deployment and commissioning activities, we would also appreciate your confirmation as to whether an extension of the project delivery timeline is planned or may be considered.	Bidders are advised that an extension to the bid submission date has been provided as indicated in Addendum 1 circulated to all potential bidders, placed online and in widely circulated Newspapers. The revised bid submission date is 22 nd September 2026.
Section VII: 1.5: Performance Requirements of the Information System 1.3.1.2.2.1.1 Laser Personalization Systems:	To ensure that our proposed configuration is fully aligned with the intended operational requirements, could you kindly confirm whether the stated throughput of 2,000 cards per hour refers to the combined output of the two laser personalization machines, with each machine providing approximately 1,000 cards per hour? Please also clarify whether 2,000 cards per hour represents the maximum performance expected from the complete two-machine personalization system	Clarification on Sub-clause 3.1.2: Bidders are advised that the stipulated minimum duplex printing speed of 2,000 cards per hour represents the aggregate, combined output of the two (2) required laser personalization machines. Consequently, each individual machine must achieve a minimum throughput of 1,000 cards per hour

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response								
Clause 3.4 of Section VII (Polycarbonate Cards, Qty: 2 million)	Clause 3.4 of Section VII (Polycarbonate Cards, Qty: 2 million) specifies the card in considerable detail.	Bidders are advised that this procurement is for the supply of two (2) million chipless polycarbonate (PC) cards. Consequently, all technical specifications and requirements relating to integrated circuits (chips) on blank cards are non-applicable and are hereby excluded from the technical scope of this tender. It must also be noted that the hardware procurement for personalization equipment is independent from the 2,000,000 blank card supply requirements. The NRB maintains the flexibility to upgrade to smart (chip-based) cards in future iterations based on prevailing strategic requirements. The NRB currently prints digitally signed biometric QR code which includes the biodata, face and fingerprint biometric information.								
	Sub-clause 3.4.1 prescribes the card construction and durability standards;									
	Sub-clauses 3.4.2 and 3.4.3 prescribe the card body security features for the front and back faces; sub-clause 3.4.4 prescribes the personalization security features; and sub-clause 3.4.6 prescribes fourteen (14) named laboratory tests to be evidenced from an internationally recognized laboratory.									
	Clause 3.4 does not, however, refer at any point to an embedded integrated circuit. Neither clause 3.4 nor any of its sub-clauses mentions a chip, chip module, antenna or inlay, and no chip characteristic is specified — no interface standard, no memory capacity, no chip operating system, no security certification level and no chip access or authentication protocol									
	References to chip encoding do appear elsewhere in the document. In each case, however, the reference is either incidental to another requirement or expressly qualified:									
	<table><tr><th>RFP clause</th><th>Text as issued</th></tr><tr><td>1.5.2.4.1</td><td>“Card encoding transactions (chip/magnetic/laser engraving)”</td></tr><tr><td>2.1 — Card Personalization Integration</td><td>“Encode chip and/or barcode data (where applicable)”</td></tr><tr><td>2.4.1.4 — Key Personnel</td><td>Secure Personalization System Engineer to have experience in “chip encoding”</td></tr><tr><td>3.1.1 and 3.1.11</td><td>“Polycarbonate Smart Cards”; “Polycarbonate Smart Card personalization operations”</td></tr></table>		RFP clause	Text as issued	1.5.2.4.1	“Card encoding transactions (chip/magnetic/laser engraving)”	2.1 — Card Personalization Integration	“Encode chip and/or barcode data (where applicable)”	2.4.1.4 — Key Personnel	Secure Personalization System Engineer to have experience in “chip encoding”
RFP clause	Text as issued									
1.5.2.4.1	“Card encoding transactions (chip/magnetic/laser engraving)”									
2.1 — Card Personalization Integration	“Encode chip and/or barcode data (where applicable)”									
2.4.1.4 — Key Personnel	Secure Personalization System Engineer to have experience in “chip encoding”									
3.1.1 and 3.1.11	“Polycarbonate Smart Cards”; “Polycarbonate Smart Card personalization operations”									

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response				
	<table><tr><td>Annex Table A, Test 6</td><td>“Encoding Tests (if applicable): Chip encoding”</td></tr><tr><td>Annex Table B, Test 7</td><td>“Machine-readable features fully functional (barcode/QR/chip if applicable)”</td></tr></table> We further note that the terms ISO/IEC 7816, ISO/IEC 14443, ICAO Doc 9303, Logical Data Structure (LDS), Common Criteria and applet do not appear anywhere in the Request for Proposals document. At the same time, the Purchaser's Requirements call for hardware security modules for cryptographic operations, a secure key management lifecycle, digital signature enforcement for card personalization, and an ID Card Security Specialist holding PKI certifications — provisions that would ordinarily accompany a contactless or dual-interface electronic identity chip carrying a signed data structure. The practical consequence is that Proposals may be prepared on materially different bases. One Proposer may reasonably price a certified dual-interface eID chip with an ICAO-compliant data structure and the associated public key infrastructure; another may reasonably price a polycarbonate card body with no electronic component, relying on the express qualification “if applicable” in the acceptance tests. Both readings appear defensible on the wording as issued, yet they differ substantially in the card unit price, in the configuration and price of the two personalization systems (specifically the provision of contact and contactless encoding stations), in the scope of the personalization software, and in the acceptance testing regime. We respectfully submit that this materially affects the comparability of Proposals We should therefore be grateful for the Purchaser's clarification of the following:	Annex Table A, Test 6	“Encoding Tests (if applicable): Chip encoding”	Annex Table B, Test 7	“Machine-readable features fully functional (barcode/QR/chip if applicable)”	
Annex Table A, Test 6	“Encoding Tests (if applicable): Chip encoding”					
Annex Table B, Test 7	“Machine-readable features fully functional (barcode/QR/chip if applicable)”					

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	• Is the supply of an embedded integrated circuit (chip) within the 2,000,000 polycarbonate cards mandatory, or is it optional? • If mandatory, is the required interface contact only (ISO/IEC 7816), contactless only (ISO/IEC 14443 Type A or Type B), or dual-interface? • What are the minimum chip characteristics required — available user memory following the operating system and applet, chip operating system (Java Card or native), and minimum security certification (for example Common Criteria EAL 5+ or EAL 6+, or equivalent)? • Is compliance with ICAO Doc 9303 required? If so, please confirm the edition, whether LDS1 or LDS2 applies, and which Data Groups are to be populated. • Which chip access and authentication protocols are required — Basic Access Control (BAC), Password Authenticated Connection Establishment (PACE), Extended Access Control (EAC), Active Authentication and/or Chip Authentication? • Is the Document Security Object to be signed? If so, are the Country Signing Certification Authority and Document Signer functions within the scope of this contract, or are they retained by the National Registration Bureau? • Clause 2.1 requires biometric data (facial image, fingerprint references and signature image) to be retrieved from the National Registration and Identity System. Are any of these data to be written to the chip, and if so in what format and at what template size (for example ISO/IEC 19794)? • Is there an existing Malawi National ID chip, applet or card profile with which the new cards must be interoperable, including compatibility with card readers and verification infrastructure already deployed?	

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response												
	• The opening paragraph of clause 3.4 requires the bidder to supply “pre-personalized polycarbonate cards”. We understand this to mean card bodies carrying all card body security features but no cardholder data. Please confirm, and please confirm separately whether chip pre-initialization is within the card supplier's scope and, if so, which party holds and manages the transport keys. • Are chip operating system and applet licences included within the card unit price, and are any per-card royalties payable by the Purchaser? • If a chip is mandatory, would the Purchaser consider amending the qualifications “(where applicable)” in clause 2.1 and “(if applicable)” in Annex Table A Test 6 and Annex Table B Test 7, so that the pre commissioning and operational acceptance regime is unambiguous?													
Greyscale versus full-colour personalization	In the course of the same review we identified what appears to be an internal inconsistency in the document as issued. The requirement for the personalized portrait is expressed as greyscale in six places and as full colour in two places: <table><tr><th>RFP clause</th><th>Text as issued</th></tr><tr><td>3.1.3</td><td>“Produce Laser Engraved Text, Greyscale Picture, Security features in Stacked Layers...”</td></tr><tr><td>3.1.11</td><td>“...fiber-optic or diode-based Laser & greyscale printing technology...”</td></tr><tr><td>3.2.3.1.2</td><td>“Power Supply and Control PC for laser & greyscale printing personalization operations”</td></tr><tr><td>3.4.4</td><td>“Stacked-Layer Grey Scale Personalization”</td></tr><tr><td>Section III, Category 2, criterion 1</td><td>“Laser Engraved Text, Greyscale Picture...”</td></tr></table>	RFP clause	Text as issued	3.1.3	“Produce Laser Engraved Text, Greyscale Picture, Security features in Stacked Layers...”	3.1.11	“...fiber-optic or diode-based Laser & greyscale printing technology...”	3.2.3.1.2	“Power Supply and Control PC for laser & greyscale printing personalization operations”	3.4.4	“Stacked-Layer Grey Scale Personalization”	Section III, Category 2, criterion 1	“Laser Engraved Text, Greyscale Picture...”	This is an anomaly; it should be greyscale instead of full color. Therefore, 1. Section 3.2.2.1.1 replace “Picture: 600 dpi or higher in full colour.” with “Picture: 600 dpi or higher in Greyscale. 2. Section III Qualification Criteria – Supply of Polycarbonate Cards replace “Stacked-Layer Full-Color personalization” with “Stacked-Layer Greyscale personalization”
RFP clause	Text as issued													
3.1.3	“Produce Laser Engraved Text, Greyscale Picture, Security features in Stacked Layers...”													
3.1.11	“...fiber-optic or diode-based Laser & greyscale printing technology...”													
3.2.3.1.2	“Power Supply and Control PC for laser & greyscale printing personalization operations”													
3.4.4	“Stacked-Layer Grey Scale Personalization”													
Section III, Category 2, criterion 1	“Laser Engraved Text, Greyscale Picture...”													

Sections of the RFB	Question		Response
	Section III, Category 2, criterion 2	“Picture: 600 dpi or higher greyscale”	
	3.2.2.1.1	“Picture: 600 dpi or higher in full colour.”	
	Section III, Qualification Criteria — Supply of Polycarbonate Cards	“Stacked-Layer Full-Color personalization”	
	The distinction is fundamental to the configuration offered. Greyscale personalization of a polycarbonate card is achieved by laser engraving alone. Full-colour personalization requires an additional colour printing subsystem on each personalization machine — typically surface pre-treatment, a colour print module and a curing stage — together with a card construction able to receive and retain colour print. The two configurations differ materially in machine price, machine footprint, throughput, consumable cost and card construction. We note in particular that the two full-colour references appear in the marking resolution requirement and in the qualification criteria applicable to the polycarbonate card manufacturer, both of which are provisions against which compliance will be assessed. We should be grateful for the Purchaser's clarification of the following: • Is the required personalized portrait greyscale (laser engraved), or full colour? • If greyscale is required, we understand that clause 3.2.2.1.1 and the polycarbonate card qualification criterion in Section III would be corrected accordingly. Please confirm. • If full colour is required, please confirm the colour printing technology expected, and confirm that clauses 3.1.3, 3.1.11,		

Sections of the RFB	Question	Response
	3.2.3.1.2 and 3.4.4 and Category 2 criteria 1 and 2 of Section III would be corrected accordingly. In either case, please confirm the requirement for “Stacked-Layer” personalization and how compliance is to be evidenced at acceptance.	
Request	Both matters affect the technical configuration and the price of the Proposal, and in our respectful submission both affect the comparability of Proposals across bidders. We should therefore be grateful if the Purchaser's responses could be issued as an Addendum under ITP 8 and circulated to all Proposers who have obtained the Request for Proposals document. Should the responses materially alter the configuration required, we would respectfully invite the Purchaser to consider whether an extension of the deadline for submission of Proposals is warranted, so that all Proposers may reflect the clarified requirements in their technical and financial Proposals.	Bidders are advised that the clarifications made did not lead to material changes, as such, the closing date for bid submission remains as communicated through Addendum No. 1. Addendum No. 2 revises the specifications as made in the clarifications.

It is our hope that the responses provided will assist in finalizing your proposal.

Kind Regards